

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Team Capability Heatmap

Roll a detailed skills matrix up into a one-page red/amber/green view your leadership will actually read.

Purpose

A heatmap summarises the team's capability at the level a busy stakeholder can absorb in thirty seconds: for each capability area, how much coverage there is, how deep it goes, and whether it depends on one person. Where the skills matrix is your working document, the heatmap is your communication and investment-case document.

When to use it

- To make the case for a hire or for training budget to a time-poor executive.
- In a quarterly business review, to show how the team's shape is changing.
- When a risk (an unstaffed capability, a key-person dependency) needs to be visible to people above you.
- As the cover page for a detailed skills matrix — summary first, detail behind it.

Instructions

1. Group your competencies into capability areas that mean something to the business.
2. For each area, capture three things: Coverage (how many people are at Working or above), Depth (the highest level reached), and Key-person risk (is it held by one person?).
3. Assign a RAG rating from those three, using the rule below — do not rate on gut feel.
4. Add a single recommended action per area so the map drives a decision, not just a discussion.

RAG rule (so ratings are consistent)

Rating	Meaning	Trigger
Green	Healthy	Two or more people at Working+, at least one Proficient, no single-person dependency.
Amber	At risk	Adequate today but fragile — either shallow (nobody Proficient) or dependent on one person.
Red	Exposed	Nobody past Awareness, or a business-critical capability with no cover at all.

Worked example

Northstar's team of six, rolled up from the skills matrix. Coverage counts engineers at Working (2) or above.

Capability area	Coverage	Depth (high)	Key-person risk	RAG	Recommended action
Exploratory & test design	5 of 6	Expert (Sofia)	No	Green	Protect it; use it to mentor the rest.
Functional / defect analysis	4 of 6	Proficient	No	Green	Maintain.
UI automation	2 of 6	Proficient (Dan)	Yes — Dan only	Amber	Spread ownership; see Dan's IDP.
CI/CD & pipelines	1 of 6	Proficient (Dan)	Yes — Dan only	Amber	Cross-train urgently; single point of failure.
API / contract testing	4 of 6	Working	No	Amber	Grow one person to Proficient; public API sold to partners.
Payments / finance domain	5 of 6	Expert (Ravi)	Depth on Ravi only	Amber	Document domain knowledge; reduce reliance on Ravi.
Performance testing	0 of 6	Awareness	N/A — nobody	Red	Hire or buy in; needed for the SLA-backed B2B API.
Security awareness	2 of 6	Working	No	Amber	Baseline training for all; identify a lead.
Accessibility	1 of 6	Working (Grace)	Yes — Grace only	Red	Legal/reputational exposure; build cover.
Mentoring & coaching	2 of 6	Proficient (Sofia)	Concentrated on Sofia	Amber	Develop a second coach.

The one-page story this tells leadership: the team is excellent at manual/exploratory testing and reasonable on domain, but has two Red holes (performance, accessibility) and its automation and pipeline capability hangs entirely off one person who is burning out. That is a clear, evidenced case for a specific kind of hire — not a vague plea for "more testers".

How to interpret the results

- Red is a decision, not a status. Every Red should have an owner and a date, or it is not being managed.
- Amber driven by key-person risk is often more dangerous than Amber driven by shallowness — shallowness degrades gracefully, a single owner leaving does not.
- A wall of Green is a signal to check your standards, not to celebrate — either you are genuinely elite or you are grading yourself too kindly.
- Use the heatmap to frame investment as risk reduction. "This Red costs us the B2B SLA deal" moves budget; "we'd like more headcount" does not.

Blank reusable version

Capability area	Coverage (n at Working+)	Depth (high)	Key-person risk?	RAG	Recommended action

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Rating by feel instead of the coverage/depth/key-person rule, so nobody can challenge or reproduce it. Colouring everything amber to look safe, which tells the reader nothing. Presenting the heatmap with no recommended actions, turning a decision tool into decoration. Hiding key-person risk behind a healthy-looking coverage number — "5 of 6" still hides that only one of them has any depth.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Executives fund coloured squares they understand far faster than spreadsheets they don't. Lead with the heatmap, keep the full matrix as your evidence, and always translate a Red into the business outcome it threatens — that is the sentence that unlocks budget.